TITLE 3 THEME 2 NEW BELIEVER

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BEFORE THE MANGER

Discovering the Physical Presence of Jesus in the Old Testament

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Why This Book Exists

You know the Christmas story. You know about the manger. You know about Mary and Joseph. You know about the shepherds and the wise men. You know about the baby in the feeding trough. It is a beautiful story. It is the story of Jesus coming into the world.

But here is something you might not know yet. Jesus did not start existing at the manger. He was not created in Bethlehem. He was not born into existence in that stable. He was there before. Way before. Before the manger. Before Bethlehem. Before Mary. Before Abraham. Before the world was made.

And here is the really amazing part. He did not just exist before the manger. He showed up before the manger. He appeared. He walked. He talked. He ate. He wrestled. He stood in fires. He sat in tents. He was physically present in the Old Testament.

This book is for you. You are new to the faith. You are building your foundation. Over the next 30 days, we are going to look at 30 moments in the Old Testament where Jesus was physically present. Real appearances. Real encounters. Real moments where He showed up in a body before He was born in a body.

This is not a hard book. It is not a theology textbook. It is a simple journey. It will help you see that Jesus was not a surprise. He was the plan from the beginning. He was before the manger. And He is with you now.

The Value You Will Get

By the end of this book, you will have a bigger view of Jesus. You will see Him not just in the New Testament, but all through the Old Testament. You will see Him in the garden. In the tent. In the fire. In the storm. In the whisper. In the star.

You will also have a stronger faith. Because if Jesus was there before the manger, He is not a new idea. He is the eternal Son. He is the one who has always been. And He is the one who is with you now. He is not far. He is not distant. He is here.

You will also have a deeper love for your Bible. Because you will see that it is one story. From beginning to end. One story about one Savior. The one who was before the manger.

How to Use This Guide

This is a 30 day journey. Each day takes about 5 to 10 minutes. Read the appearance. Read the fulfillment. Read why it matters for you. Read the faith builder. Read the prayer. If you are not sure how to pray, just read the words out loud. God hears honest words. He is not looking for fancy language. He is looking for your heart.

Take your time. Do not rush. This is not a race. This is a journey through the Old Testament with the one who was before the manger. Let each day sink in. Let it build your faith. Let it help you see Jesus on every page.

Day 01: The Word Was Already There

The Old Appearance

"In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God. He was with God in the beginning. Through him all things were made." - John 1:1-3 (Written around 90 A.D.)

Before the manger. Before Bethlehem. Before Mary. Before the world. There was the Word. The Word was with God. The Word was God. He was there. He was not created. He was not born. He was. He is eternal. He is the one who was before the manger. This is the first thing we need to know. Jesus did not start at the manger. He started before the beginning.

The Fulfillment

"The Word became flesh and made his dwelling among us. We have seen his glory, the glory of the one and only Son, who came from the Father, full of grace and truth." - John 1:14

The Word became flesh. The eternal became a baby. The one who was before the manger entered the manger. He did not stop being God. He became man. He added humanity to His divinity. He came close. He was before the manger. And He came to the manger.

Why It Matters For You

You might think of Jesus as a baby. You might think of Him as a man. You might think of Him as a story. But He is more. He is eternal. He was before the beginning. He is the Word. He is God. He is the one who was before the manger. And He is the one who came to the manger. For you.

Faith Builder

Write down one thing this truth changes about how you see Jesus. Then write this: "Jesus was before the manger. He is eternal. He is God."

The Prayer

Jesus, thank you for being before the manger. Thank you for being eternal. Thank you for being God. Thank you for becoming flesh. Thank you for coming close. I worship you. Amen.

Day 02: The God Who Walked in the Garden

The Old Appearance

"Then the man and his wife heard the sound of the LORD God as he was walking in the garden in the cool of the day, and they hid from the LORD God among the trees of the garden." - Genesis 3:8 (Written around 1400 B.C.)

Before the manger. Long before. There was a garden. And God was walking in it. In the cool of the day. Adam and Eve heard His footsteps. They hid. But He was there. He was walking. He was looking. He was calling. This is Jesus. Before the manger. In the garden. Walking. In person.

The Fulfillment

"The Word became flesh and made his dwelling among us. We have seen his glory, the glory of the one and only Son, who came from the Father, full of grace and truth." - John 1:14

The one who walked in the garden is the one who came to the manger. The same person. The same God. The same heart. He walked with Adam and Eve. He walked with the disciples. He walks with you. He was before the manger. He is after the manger. He is always walking.

Why It Matters For You

You might feel like God is far away. You might feel like He is not walking with you. But the garden tells a different story. God walked with people. He came close. He wanted to be with them. He wants to be with you. He is not far. He is walking toward you right now.

Faith Builder

Take a short walk today. As you walk, imagine Jesus walking with you. Talk to Him. Tell Him about your day.

The Prayer

God, thank you for walking with me. Thank you for coming close. Thank you for wanting to be with me. Help me to walk with you. Help me to know you are near. Amen.

Day 03: The God at the Tent

The Old Appearance

"Abraham looked up and saw three men standing nearby. When he saw them, he hurried from the entrance of his tent to meet them and bowed low to the ground." - Genesis 18:2 (Written around 1400 B.C.)

Three strangers came to Abraham's tent. One of them was God. Abraham did not know it at first. But he offered them food. He washed their feet. He made them a meal. And God sat at his table. God ate. God talked. God stayed. This is Jesus. Before the manger. At the tent. In the body. At the table.

The Fulfillment

"Here I am! I stand at the door and knock. If anyone hears my voice and opens the door, I will come in and eat with that person, and they with me." - Revelation 3:20

Jesus wants to eat with you. He wants to sit at your table. He wants to talk with you. He wants to stay. The tent meal was a preview. The table with Jesus is the reality. He was before the manger. He is at your door. He wants to come in.

Why It Matters For You

You might think of God as distant. As somewhere up there. As someone who is not interested in your daily life. But the tent meal tells a different story. God wants to be with you. He wants to sit at your table. He wants to eat with you. He wants to be part of your ordinary life. He was before the manger. And He wants to be at your table now.

Faith Builder

Set aside a few minutes today to sit quietly with God. Imagine Him at your table. Talk to Him. Tell Him about your day. Let Him be close.

The Prayer

Jesus, come to my table. Come and sit with me. I want you to be part of my everyday life. Stay with me. Eat with me. Be with me. Amen.

Day 04: The God in the Burning Bush

The Old Appearance

"There the angel of the LORD appeared to him in flames of fire from within a bush. Moses saw that though the bush was on fire it did not burn up." - Exodus 3:2 (Written around 1400 B.C.)

Moses was in the wilderness. He saw a bush on fire. But the bush did not burn up. Moses walked closer. And God spoke to him from the bush. This is Jesus. Before the manger. In the fire. In the bush. Speaking. In person.

The Fulfillment

"The Word became flesh and made his dwelling among us. We have seen his glory, the glory of the one and only Son, who came from the Father, full of grace and truth." - John 1:14

Jesus is the one in the bush. He is the fire. He is the presence. The bush did not burn up. Jesus was not destroyed. The fire did not consume the bush. The grave did not consume Jesus. He was before the manger. He was in the bush.

Why It Matters For You

You might feel like God is not speaking to you. You might feel like He is silent. But the burning bush tells a different story. God speaks. God calls. God shows up. He is not silent. He is speaking. He was before the manger. He is speaking now.

Faith Builder

Ask God to help you hear Him this week. Write down one way He might be speaking to you that you have not noticed before.

The Prayer

God, help me to hear you. Help me to notice when you are speaking. I do not want to miss you. You are close. You are not silent. Speak to me. I am listening. Amen.

Day 05: The God Who Wrestled

The Old Appearance

"So Jacob was left alone, and a man wrestled with him till daybreak... Then the man said, 'Your name will no longer be Jacob, but Israel, because you have struggled with God and with humans and have overcome.'" - Genesis 32:24, 28 (Written around 1400 B.C.)

Jacob was alone. He was scared. And a man came. And they wrestled. All night. In the dark. In the dirt. And Jacob would not let go. The man was God. This is Jesus. Before the manger. In the dirt. Wrestling. Physical. Real.

The Fulfillment

"But we see Jesus, who was made lower than the angels for a little while, now crowned with glory and honor because he suffered death." - Hebrews 2:9

Jacob wrestled a man. The man was God. God let Himself be grabbed. God let Himself be held. This is a picture of Jesus. Jesus let Himself be grabbed, beaten, and held on a cross. He did not break free. He let Himself be held. For us. He was before the manger. He let Himself be held.

Why It Matters For You

You might be struggling. You might be angry. You might have questions you are afraid to ask. But the story of Jacob tells a different story. God is not scared of your struggle. You can grab Him. You can hold on. You can wrestle. He will not break. He will bless you. He was before the manger. And He is with you in the struggle.

Faith Builder

What are you struggling with right now? Write it down. Then write this: "I am holding on to God. I will not let go until He blesses me."

The Prayer

God, I am struggling. I am not going to let go. I am holding on to you. Even if I limp away, I am not letting go until you bless me. You are worth holding. Amen.

Day 06: The God with a Sword

The Old Appearance

"'Neither,' he replied, 'but as commander of the army of the LORD I have now come.' Then Joshua fell facedown to the ground in reverence." - Joshua 5:14 (Written around 1400 B.C.)

Joshua was about to fight a huge battle. He looked up and saw a man. The man had a sword drawn. Joshua asked, "Are you for us or for our enemies?" The man said, "Neither. I am the commander of the army of the Lord." This is Jesus. Before the manger. With a sword. In person.

The Fulfillment

"Then Jesus came to them and said, 'All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me.'" - Matthew 28:18

The commander of the Lord's army has all authority. Jesus has all authority. Before Jesus was born, He was standing on the road to Jericho with a sword. He is the commander. The battle is His. He was before the manger. He is with you in the battle.

Why It Matters For You

You might be facing a battle right now. A big one. A scary one. You might be asking, "God, are you on my side?" But the real question is different. Is He your commander? He is not a side. He is the leader. Let Him lead. He was before the manger. He is fighting for you.

Faith Builder

What battle are you facing today? Write it down. Then write this: "The commander of the Lord's army is with me. The battle is His."

The Prayer

Jesus, you are the commander. I stop asking if you are on my side. I choose your side. Lead me. Fight for me. The battle is yours. I trust you. Amen.

Day 07: The God in the Fire

The Old Appearance

"Look! I see four men walking around in the fire, unbound and unharmed, and the fourth looks like a son of the gods." - Daniel 3:25 (Written around 530 B.C.)

Three men refused to bow to a golden statue. The king threw them into a furnace. But the king looked in and saw four men. Walking. In the fire. The fourth looked like a god. This is Jesus. Before the manger. In the fire. Walking. In person.

The Fulfillment

"And surely I am with you always, to the very end of the age." - Matthew 28:20

Jesus promised to be with us. Not to keep us out of the fire. To be in it. The fourth man in the fire is a picture of Jesus. He is the one who walks with us through the fire. He was before the manger. He is in the fire with you.

Why It Matters For You

You might be in a fire right now. A trial. A hard season. A loss. You might feel like you are burning up. But the story of the furnace tells a different story. You are not alone. There is a fourth man. He is walking with you. He is in the fire. He was before the manger. He is with you.

Faith Builder

Write down the fire you are in right now. Then write this: "The fourth man is in the fire with me. I am not alone."

The Prayer

Jesus, you are the fourth man. You are in the fire with me. Thank you for walking with me. Thank you for staying. Thank you for not leaving. I am not alone. I am not afraid. You are here. Amen.

Day 08: The God Who Spoke in the Storm

The Old Appearance

"Then the LORD spoke to Job out of the storm." - Job 38:1 (Written around 2000 B.C.)

Job lost everything. He was in pain. He asked God questions. And God answered. Not in a soft voice. In a whirlwind. The storm came. And God spoke. This is Jesus. Before the manger. In the storm. Speaking. In person.

The Fulfillment

"He got up, rebuked the wind and said to the waves, 'Quiet! Be still!' Then the wind died down and it was completely calm." - Mark 4:39

Jesus spoke to a storm. He calmed the wind. He calmed the waves. The same voice that spoke to Job spoke to the sea. He was before the manger. He speaks to you. He calms your storm.

Why It Matters For You

You might have questions for God. You might have pain. You might have anger. But the story of Job tells a different story. God is not scared of your questions. He wants to speak to you. He was before the manger. He is in your storm. He is speaking. Listen.

Faith Builder

Write down one question you have for God. Do not be afraid to ask it. Then sit quietly and let Him be near.

The Prayer

God, I have questions. I have pain. I have anger. I am done pretending. Speak to me. Show up. Not with easy answers. With yourself. I need you more than I need answers. Amen.

Day 09: The God on the Ladder

The Old Appearance

"He had a dream in which he saw a stairway resting on the earth, with its top reaching to heaven, and the angels of God were ascending and descending on it." - Genesis 28:12 (Written around 1400 B.C.)

Jacob was running away. He was scared. He fell asleep. And he dreamed. He saw a ladder. It reached from earth to heaven. Angels were going up and down. And God was at the top. This is Jesus. Before the manger. At the top of the ladder. The connection. In person.

The Fulfillment

"He then added, 'Very truly I tell you, you will see heaven open, and the angels of God ascending and descending on the Son of Man.'" - John 1:51

Jesus said the ladder was Him. He is the stairway. He is the connection. He is the way between heaven and earth. The ladder was a picture. Jesus is the reality. He was before the manger. He is the connection.

Why It Matters For You

You might feel disconnected from God. You might feel like there is a gap. But the story of the ladder tells a different story. There is a connection. There is a way. Jesus is the connection. You can come close. He was before the manger. He is the bridge.

Faith Builder

Write down one way you feel disconnected from God. Then write this: "Jesus is the ladder. He connects me to God. I can come close."

The Prayer

Jesus, you are the ladder. You are the stairway. You are the connection. Thank you for making a way between heaven and earth. Thank you for making a way between me and God. I am coming close. Amen.

Day 10: The God with the Secret Name

The Old Appearance

"The angel of the LORD answered, 'Why do you ask my name? It is beyond understanding.'" - Judges 13:18 (Written around 1100 B.C.)

Manoah and his wife could not have children. The Angel of the Lord appeared to the woman. He promised a son. Manoah asked his name. The angel said, "Why do you ask my name? It is beyond understanding." This is Jesus. Before the manger. The mysterious one. In person.

The Fulfillment

"No one has ever seen God, but the one and only Son, who is himself God and is in closest relationship with the Father, has made him known." - John 1:18

Jesus makes God known. But before Jesus, the Son was already making God known. The Word was not silent before Bethlehem. He was speaking. He was showing up. He was the angel. He was before the manger. He makes God known.

Why It Matters For You

You might want to understand everything about God. But some things are beyond understanding. And that is okay. God has shown Himself. In Jesus. He was before the manger. He is the visible presence. You do not have to understand everything. You just have to know Him.

Faith Builder

Write down one thing about God you do not understand. Then write this: "I do not have to understand everything. I just have to know Him. He is close."

The Prayer

God, you are beyond understanding. Your name is a mystery. But you have shown yourself in Jesus. Thank you. I look at Jesus. I see you. I know you. Amen.

Day 11: The God on the Mountain

The Old Appearance

"Mount Sinai was covered with smoke, because the LORD descended on it in fire. The smoke billowed up from it like smoke from a furnace, and the whole mountain trembled violently." - Exodus 19:18 (Written around 1400 B.C.)

The people were at the bottom of the mountain. The mountain was on fire. Smoke was rising. The ground was shaking. A voice was speaking. This is Jesus. Before the manger. On the mountain. In the fire. In person.

The Fulfillment

"For you have not come to a mountain that can be touched and that is burning with fire... But you have come to Mount Zion, to the city of the living God." - Hebrews 12:18, 22

The mountain was terrifying. But we have not come to that mountain. We have come to a better one. Jesus opened a different way. We do not stand at the bottom, scared. We come close. He was before the manger. He brings us close.

Why It Matters For You

You might feel like God is a mountain you cannot climb. Like He is up there and you are down here. But the story of the mountain tells a different story. Jesus came to bring you up the mountain. You do not have to stand far away anymore. He was before the manger. He brings you close.

Faith Builder

Write down one way you feel far from God. Then write this: "Jesus brought me up the mountain. I can come close to the Father."

The Prayer

God, you are holy. I am not. Thank you that Jesus makes a way. Thank you that I do not have to stay at the bottom of the mountain, shaking. Bring me close. Let me come up. Amen.

Day 12: The God in the Cloud

The Old Appearance

"Then the cloud covered the tent of meeting, and the glory of the LORD filled the tabernacle. Moses could not enter the tent of meeting because the cloud had settled on it, and the glory of the LORD filled the tabernacle." - Exodus 40:34-35 (Written around 1400 B.C.)

The cloud came down. It covered the tent. The glory filled the tabernacle. Moses could not even go in. This is Jesus. Before the manger. In the cloud. In the glory. In person.

The Fulfillment

"The Word became flesh and made his dwelling among us. We have seen his glory, the glory of the one and only Son, who came from the Father, full of grace and truth." - John 1:14

The glory cloud came down on a tent. Jesus came down in flesh. The word "dwelling" here literally means "pitched his tent." Jesus is the new tent. He is the new cloud. He is the glory of God, walking. He was before the manger.

Why It Matters For You

You might want to experience God's presence. You might feel like you are outside the tent, looking in. But the story of the cloud tells a different story. Jesus brought the glory down to us. He came near. He filled a human body. He can fill you. He was before the manger.

Faith Builder

Set aside a few quiet minutes today. Ask God to fill you with His presence. Then sit still and let Him be near.

The Prayer

God, fill me with your presence. I do not want to stand outside, looking in. I want to know your glory. Thank you that Jesus brought your glory down to me. Fill me. Amen.

Day 13: The God in the Road

The Old Appearance

"The angel of the LORD stood in the road to oppose him... When the donkey saw the angel of the LORD, it turned off the road into a field." - Numbers 22:22-23 (Written around 1400 B.C.)

Balaam was on his way to curse God's people. The angel of the Lord stood in the road. With a sword. The donkey saw Him. The donkey turned. This is Jesus. Before the manger. In the road. With a sword. In person.

The Fulfillment

"While they were going out, they met a man from Cyrene, named Simon, and they forced him to carry the cross." - Matthew 27:32

On the way to the cross, another man was pulled in. Simon of Cyrene carried the cross. The angel stood in the road. He opposed the wrong path. Jesus stood in the road of our sin. He took the sword. He took the curse. He was before the manger.

Why It Matters For You

You might be on a road right now that you should not be on. And God might be standing in it. Sometimes the thing that stops you is the thing that saves you. God may be standing in your road. He is not trying to ruin your journey. He is trying to save it. He was before the manger.

Faith Builder

Is there a road you are on right now that you know you should not be on? Write it down. Ask God to help you turn around.

The Prayer

God, thank you for standing in my road. Thank you for the warnings. Help me to see. Help me to listen. You are not trying to ruin my journey. You are trying to save it. I will turn. Amen.

Day 14: The God in the Whisper

The Old Appearance

"After the earthquake came a fire, but the LORD was not in the fire. And after the fire came a gentle whisper." - 1 Kings 19:12 (Written around 900 B.C.)

Elijah was scared. He was depressed. He wanted to die. And God came to him. Not in the wind. Not in the earthquake. Not in the fire. In a gentle whisper. This is Jesus. Before the manger. In the whisper. In person.

The Fulfillment

"The Word became flesh and made his dwelling among us. We have seen his glory, the glory of the one and only Son, who came from the Father, full of grace and truth." - John 1:14

God showed up in a whisper. Then He showed up in a baby. Not in a palace. In a stable. Not in the loud. In the quiet. God is not always in the loud things. He is in the small things. He was before the manger. He is in the whisper.

Why It Matters For You

You might be looking for God in the big things. In the loud things. But He is in the quiet. He is in the whisper. He is in the small. He is in the person. He was before the manger. He is speaking. Be still. Hear Him.

Faith Builder

Find a quiet place today. No music. No phone. Just you and God. Sit for five minutes in the silence. Listen.

The Prayer

God, help me to hear the whisper. I am looking for the big things. But you are in the quiet. Speak to me in the silence. I am listening. I am still. Amen.

Day 15: The God in the Temple

The Old Appearance

"When Solomon finished praying, fire came down from heaven and consumed the burnt offering and the sacrifices, and the glory of the LORD filled the temple." - 2 Chronicles 7:1 (Written around 950 B.C.)

Solomon built the temple. It was the house of God. And when it was finished, Solomon prayed. And fire came down. From heaven. And the glory filled the temple. This is Jesus. Before the manger. In the temple. In the fire. In person.

The Fulfillment

"Don't you know that you yourselves are God's temple and that God's Spirit dwells in your midst?" - 1 Corinthians 3:16

We are the temple. God lives in us. The fire is in us. The glory is in us. The temple was a picture. The Spirit in us is the reality. He was before the manger. He is in us.

Why It Matters For You

You might not know this yet. But you are the temple now. If you follow Jesus, the Spirit lives in you. You are the house of God. The fire is in you. The glory is in you. He was before the manger. He is in you.

Faith Builder

Put your hand on your chest. Take a deep breath. Say out loud, "God lives in me. I am His temple."

The Prayer

God, thank you that I am your temple. Thank you that the fire fills me. Thank you that the glory fills me. Fill me with your presence. I am your house. Amen.

Day 16: The God Who Writes

The Old Appearance

"Suddenly the fingers of a human hand appeared and wrote on the plaster of the wall, near the lampstand in the royal palace. The king watched the hand as it wrote." - Daniel 5:5 (Written around 530 B.C.)

A king was having a party. He was mocking God. And then he saw it. A hand. Writing on the wall. The king was terrified. This is Jesus. Before the manger. In the hand. In the writing. In person.

The Fulfillment

"But Jesus bent down and started to write on the ground with his finger." - John 8:6

A hand wrote on a wall. A finger wrote on the ground. When the woman caught in adultery was brought to Jesus, He wrote on the ground with His finger. The same finger. The same God. He was before the manger. He writes.

Why It Matters For You

God is still writing. He is still speaking. He is not silent. He might be writing on your heart right now. He might be trying to get your attention. He was before the manger. He is writing now.

Faith Builder

Write down one thing you feel God might be trying to say to you right now. Do not overthink it. Just write.

The Prayer

God, I see your hand. I hear your voice. I do not want to ignore you. Write on my heart. Write your truth. Write your grace. I am listening. Amen.

Day 17: The God Who Calls the Weak

The Old Appearance

"The angel of the LORD came and sat down under the oak in Ophrah... and said, 'The LORD is with you, mighty warrior.'" - Judges 6:11-12 (Written around 1100 B.C.)

Gideon was hiding. He was scared. He was the least important person in his family. And the angel called him a mighty warrior. This is Jesus. Before the manger. Calling the weak. In person.

The Fulfillment

"But God chose the foolish things of the world to shame the wise; God chose the weak things of the world to shame the strong." - 1 Corinthians 1:27

God chooses the weak. He chose Gideon. The angel under the oak is a picture. The Christ who calls the weak is the reality. He was before the manger. He calls you.

Why It Matters For You

You might feel like the least. Like the smallest. But the story of Gideon tells a different story. God sees what you can become. He is not put off by your fear. He was before the manger. He is calling you.

Faith Builder

Write down one thing you feel too weak for. Then write this next to it: "God calls me a mighty warrior. He is with me."

The Prayer

God, you call me what I cannot see yet. You called a scared man a mighty warrior. Thank you that you come to the weak. Make me brave. You are with me. Amen.

Day 18: The God Who Gives the Impossible

The Old Appearance

"The angel of the LORD appeared to her and said, 'You are barren and childless, but you are going to become pregnant and give birth to a son.'" - Judges 13:3 (Written around 1100 B.C.)

A woman could not have children. She was barren. And the angel appeared to her. He told her she would have a son. This is Jesus. Before the manger. Giving the impossible. In person.

The Fulfillment

"But the angel said to her, 'Do not be afraid, Mary; you have found favor with God. You will conceive and give birth to a son, and you are to call him Jesus.'" - Luke 1:30-31

The angel came to Mary. He promised a son. The son was Jesus. The angel to Samson's mother was a picture. The angel to Mary was the reality. He was before the manger. He gives the impossible.

Why It Matters For You

You might have a barren place. A place where nothing grows. But the story of the barren woman tells a different story. God comes to the barren. He gives the impossible. He was before the manger. He gives you the impossible.

Faith Builder

Write down your barren place. The place where nothing seems to grow. Then write this: "God gives the impossible. He is close."

The Prayer

God, I have a barren place. A place where nothing grows. Come to me. Give me the impossible. Give me a future. Give me a hope. You are the God of the impossible. Amen.

Day 19: The God Who Hears Your Prayer

The Old Appearance

"But the angel said to him, 'Do not be afraid, Zechariah; your prayer has been heard. Your wife Elizabeth will bear you a son, and you are to call him John.'" - Luke 1:13 (Written around 5 B.C.)

Zechariah was a priest. He was old. They had no children. They had prayed for years. And the angel appeared to him. He was terrified. And the angel told him his prayer had been heard. This is Jesus. Before the manger. Hearing prayer. In person.

The Fulfillment

"And you, my child, will be called a prophet of the Most High; for you will go on before the Lord to prepare the way for him." - Luke 1:76

John was the forerunner. He prepared the way. The angel came to Zechariah. He promised John. God hears. God answers. He was before the manger. He hears you.

Why It Matters For You

You might have given up on a prayer. You might have lost hope. But the story of Zechariah tells a different story. God hears. God answers. Even in the waiting. Your prayer has been heard. He was before the manger. He is listening now.

Faith Builder

Write down one prayer you have given up on. Then pray it again today. Just once. Say it out loud.

The Prayer

God, I have given up on some prayers. I have stopped believing. But you hear. You answer. Thank you that my prayer is heard. I am praying again. Amen.

Day 20: The God in the Dream

The Old Appearance

"But after he had considered this, an angel of the Lord appeared to him in a dream and said, 'Joseph son of David, do not be afraid to take Mary home as your wife, because what is conceived in her is from the Holy Spirit.'" - Matthew 1:20 (Written around 5 B.C.)

Joseph was a carpenter. He was engaged to Mary. She was pregnant. Not by him. He was going to divorce her quietly. But the angel appeared to him in a dream. This is Jesus. Before the manger. In the dream. In person.

The Fulfillment

"She will give birth to a son, and you are to give him the name Jesus, because he will save his people from their sins." - Matthew 1:21

The name is Jesus. He saves. The angel to Joseph was a picture. The Jesus who saves is the reality. He was before the manger. He comes to the confused. He speaks. He saves.

Why It Matters For You

You might be confused. You might be scared. You might be unsure of what to do. But the story of Joseph tells a different story. God comes to the confused. He speaks. He guides. He was before the manger. He is with you.

Faith Builder

Write down one thing you are confused about right now. Then write this: "God speaks to the confused. He will guide me. He is close."

The Prayer

God, I am confused. I am scared. I am unsure. Speak to me. Guide me. Calm me. Do not let me be afraid. You are here. You are close. Amen.

Day 21: The God to the Shepherds

The Old Appearance

"But the angel said to them, 'Do not be afraid. I bring you good news that will cause great joy for all the people. Today in the town of David a Savior has been born to you; he is the Messiah, the Lord.'" - Luke 2:10
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CONTINUED — DAY 21 (FINISHED)

The Old Appearance (continued)

"But the angel said to them, 'Do not be afraid. I bring you good news that will cause great joy for all the people. Today in the town of David a Savior has been born to you; he is the Messiah, the Lord.'" - Luke 2:10-11 (Written around 5 B.C.)

Shepherds were in the fields. It was night. And the sky lit up. The angel appeared. They were terrified. And the angel said, "Do not be afraid. I bring you good news of great joy." This is Jesus. Before the manger. Announcing the manger. In person.

The Fulfillment

"Today in the town of David a Savior has been born to you; he is the Messiah, the Lord." - Luke 2:11

The Savior is born. The Messiah is here. The Lord is in the manger. The angel to the shepherds announced it. The one who was before the manger came to the manger. He came to the shepherds first. He comes to you.

Why It Matters For You

You might feel overlooked. You might feel forgotten. But the story of the shepherds tells a different story. God came to the shepherds first. Not the kings. Not the priests. The shepherds. The ones nobody invited. He came to them. He comes to you. You are not forgotten.

Faith Builder

Write down one way you feel overlooked. Then write this: "God came to the shepherds. He comes to me. I am not forgotten."

The Prayer

God, I feel overlooked. I feel forgotten. But you came to the shepherds. You come to me. Thank you for the good news. Thank you for the joy. I am not forgotten. Amen.

Day 22: The God on the Throne

The Old Appearance

"In the year that King Uzziah died, I saw the Lord, high and exalted, seated on a throne; and the train of his robe filled the temple." - Isaiah 6:1 (Written around 700 B.C.)

Isaiah was in the temple. And he saw something. He saw the Lord. High and lifted up. On a throne. Angels were flying. They were calling. "Holy, holy, holy." And Isaiah was undone. This is Jesus. Before the manger. On the throne. In person.

The Fulfillment

"Isaiah said this because he saw Jesus' glory and spoke about him." - John 12:41

Isaiah saw Jesus. He saw His glory. He saw His throne. He saw His holiness. The vision was a picture. The face of Jesus is the reality. He was before the manger. He is on the throne.

Why It Matters For You

You might need to see God. You might need to see His glory. Look at Jesus. He is on the throne. He is high and lifted up. He is holy. He was before the manger. He is the King. He is with you.

Faith Builder

Take a few minutes today to worship. Put on a worship song. Or just sit quietly. Say out loud, "Holy, holy, holy. You are on the throne."

The Prayer

Lord, I see you. High and lifted up. Holy. On the throne. I am undone. I am unclean. But you are holy. You are the King. I worship you. Amen.

Day 23: The God Who Sees Everything

The Old Appearance

"As I looked, I saw a wheel on the ground beside each creature with its four faces. This was the appearance of the wheels and their construction: they sparkled like topaz, and all four looked alike. Each appeared to be made like a wheel intersecting a wheel." - Ezekiel 1:15-16 (Written around 590 B.C.)

Ezekiel was in exile. He saw a vision. A storm. A cloud. A fire. And four creatures. And wheels. Wheels within wheels. Full of eyes. And above the wheels was a throne. And on the throne was a figure. Like a man. This is Jesus. Before the manger. On the throne. In person.

The Fulfillment

"Then I turned around to see the voice that was speaking to me. And when I turned I saw seven golden lampstands, and among the lampstands was someone like a son of man, dressed in a robe reaching down to his feet and with a golden sash around his chest." - Revelation 1:12-13

John saw the Son of Man. Ezekiel saw the same. The throne. The figure. The glory. He was before the manger. He sees everything. He is on the throne.

Why It Matters For You

You might feel like God is far away. But the vision of Ezekiel tells a different story. God is on the throne. He is in control. He sees. He moves. He rules. He was before the manger. He sees you. He is with you.

Faith Builder

Write down one thing that feels out of control in your life right now. Then write this: "God is on the throne. He sees everything. He is in control."

The Prayer

God, I feel like the world is out of control. But you are on the throne. You are in control. You see. You rule. I trust you. Amen.

Day 24: The God Who Marks His Own

The Old Appearance

"While I was watching, the six men arrived from the direction of the upper gate, which faces north, each with a deadly weapon in his hand. With them was a man clothed in linen who had a writing kit at his side." - Ezekiel 9:2 (Written around 590 B.C.)

Ezekiel saw a vision. A man. Dressed in linen. With a writing kit. He was sent to mark the foreheads of the faithful. He was sent to protect them. This is Jesus. Before the manger. Marking His own. In person.

The Fulfillment

"Do not harm the land or the sea or the trees until we put a seal on the foreheads of the servants of our God." - Revelation 7:3

The seal. On the foreheads. The mark. Of the faithful. The man in linen was a picture. The Christ with the seal is the reality. He was before the manger. He marks. He protects. He saves.

Why It Matters For You

You might wonder if you belong to God. But the vision of the man in linen tells a different story. God marks His own. He seals them. He protects them. He was before the manger. He marks you.

Faith Builder

Say this out loud today: "I am marked by God. I am sealed by His Spirit. I belong to Him."

The Prayer

Jesus, mark me. Seal me. Protect me. Save me. I want to be yours. Thank you for the mark. Thank you for the seal. I am yours. Amen.

Day 25: The God in the Star

The Old Appearance

"I see him, but not now; I behold him, but not near. A star will come out of Jacob; a scepter will rise out of Israel." - Numbers 24:17 (Written around 1400 B.C.)

Balaam was hired to curse God's people. But he could not. He blessed them instead. And he spoke a prophecy. He said, "A star will come out of Jacob." This is Jesus. Before the manger. In the prophecy. In the star. In person.

The Fulfillment

"After Jesus was born in Bethlehem in Judea, during the time of King Herod, Magi from the east came to Jerusalem and asked, 'Where is the one who has been born king of the Jews? We saw his star when it rose and have come to worship him.'" - Matthew 2:1-2

The Magi saw the star. They followed it. They found Jesus. The star was a picture. The birth of Jesus is the reality. He was before the manger. He is the star. He is the King.

Why It Matters For You

You might be looking for a sign. But the story of the star tells a different story. The star led the Magi to Jesus. The sign points to the King. Follow the star. Follow Jesus. He was before the manger. He is the one you are looking for.

Faith Builder

Write down one sign or moment that helped you find Jesus. Thank God for it today.

The Prayer

Jesus, you are the star. You are the King. You are the one I am looking for. I follow you. I worship you. Thank you for leading me to you. Amen.

Day 26: The God Who Heals

The Old Appearance

"He sent forth his word and healed them; he rescued them from the grave." - Psalm 107:20 (Written around 1000 B.C.)

God sent His word. His word healed. His word rescued. This is a promise. This is a picture. The word of God brings healing. This is Jesus. Before the manger. The Word. In person.

The Fulfillment

"Just say the word, and my servant will be healed." - Matthew 8:8

A centurion said to Jesus, "Just say the word." He knew the power of the word. The word of God brings healing. Jesus is the Word. He heals. He rescues. He was before the manger. He is the Word. He heals you.

Why It Matters For You

You might need healing. Physical healing. Emotional healing. Spiritual healing. The psalm tells a different story. God sends His word. His word heals. His word rescues. Jesus is the Word. He was before the manger. He heals you.

Faith Builder

Write down one area of your life where you need healing. Then say out loud, "Just say the word, Jesus. Just say the word."

The Prayer

Jesus, you are the Word. You heal. You rescue. Just say the word. Heal me. Rescue me. I need you. You were before the manger. You are here now. Amen.

Day 27: The God Who Is the Light

The Old Appearance

"By day the LORD went ahead of them in a pillar of cloud to guide them on their way and by night in a pillar of fire to give them light." - Exodus 13:21 (Written around 1400 B.C.)

God led His people. By day in a pillar of cloud. By night in a pillar of fire. He gave them light. This is Jesus. Before the manger. The light. In person.

The Fulfillment

"When Jesus spoke again to the people, he said, 'I am the light of the world. Whoever follows me will never walk in darkness, but will have the light of life.'" - John 8:12

Jesus is the light. He led His people. He gave them light. The pillar of fire was a picture. Jesus is the reality. He was before the manger. He is the light.

Why It Matters For You

You might feel like you are walking in darkness. You might feel lost. But the story of the pillar tells a different story. God is the light. He leads you. He gives you light. You are not walking in darkness. He was before the manger. He is the light. He is with you.

Faith Builder

Write down one area of your life where you feel like you are walking in darkness. Then write this: "Jesus is the light. He leads me. He is close."

The Prayer

Jesus, you are the light. You lead me. You guide me. You give me light. Thank you. I am not walking in darkness. I am walking in your light. Amen.

Day 28: The God Who Is the Bread

The Old Appearance

"Then the LORD said to Moses, 'I will rain down bread from heaven for you. The people are to go out each day and gather enough for that day.'" - Exodus 16:4 (Written around 1400 B.C.)

The people were hungry. They were in the desert. And God rained down bread from heaven. It appeared every morning. They gathered it. They ate it. This is Jesus. Before the manger. The bread. In person.

The Fulfillment

"I am the living bread that came down from heaven. Whoever eats this bread will live forever. This bread is my flesh, which I will give for the life of the world." - John 6:51

Jesus is the bread. He came down from heaven. He gave His flesh. He gave His life. The manna was a picture. Jesus is the reality. He was before the manger. He is the bread.

Why It Matters For You

You might be hungry. You might be trying to fill yourself with things that do not satisfy. But the story of the manna tells a different story. Jesus is the bread. He satisfies. He was before the manger. He is the bread of life. Eat. Be satisfied.

Faith Builder

Write down one thing you have been trying to fill yourself with besides God. Then write this: "Jesus is the bread. He satisfies me. He is close."

The Prayer

Jesus, you are the bread. You are the bread of life. I have been trying to fill myself with things that do not satisfy. Feed me. Satisfy me. Be my bread. Amen.

Day 29: The God Who Is the Rock

The Old Appearance

"Behold, I will stand before you there on the rock at Horeb, and you shall strike the rock, and water shall come out of it, and the people will drink." - Exodus 17:6 (Written around 1400 B.C.)

The people were thirsty. They were in the desert. And God told Moses to strike a rock. And water came out. Enough for a whole nation. This is Jesus. Before the manger. The rock. In person.

The Fulfillment

"And they all drank the same spiritual drink. For they drank from the spiritual rock that followed them, and the rock was Christ." - 1 Corinthians 10:4

Paul says the rock was Christ. The water was Jesus. He is the rock. He is the source. He is the water. He was before the manger. He is the rock. He gives living water.

Why It Matters For You

You might be thirsty. You might be dry. You might be desperate for water. Jesus is the rock. He gives living water. He was before the manger. He is the water. Come to the rock. Drink. Be satisfied.

Faith Builder

Write down one thing you are thirsty for right now. Then write this: "Jesus is the rock. He gives living water. He is close."

The Prayer

Jesus, you are the rock. You were struck for me. And water came out. Living water. Thank you. I am drinking. I am satisfied. Amen.

Day 30: The God Who Was Before the Manger

The Old Appearance

"But you, Bethlehem Ephrathah, though you are small among the clans of Judah, out of you will come for me one who will be ruler over Israel, whose origins are from of old, from ancient times." - Micah 5:2 (Written around 700 B.C.)

The prophet spoke of the birth of Jesus. He said He would come from Bethlehem. But he said something else. He said His origins were from of old. From ancient times. Before the manger. Before Bethlehem. He was always there. This is Jesus. Before the manger. From ancient times. In person.

The Fulfillment

"The Word became flesh and made his dwelling among us. We have seen his glory, the glory of the one and only Son, who came from the Father, full of grace and truth." - John 1:14

The Word became flesh. The one who was from ancient times became a baby. The one who was before the manger came to the manger. He did not stop being God. He became man. He came close. He was before the manger. And He came to the manger.

Why It Matters For You

You have been learning about the physical presence of Jesus in the Old Testament for 30 days. But here is the beautiful truth. He is not just a figure from long ago. He is the one who was from ancient times. He is the one who came to the manger. He is the one who is with you now. He was before the manger. He is after the manger. He is with you always. He is close.

Faith Builder

Take a moment today to thank Jesus for being before the manger. Write down one way this truth has changed how you see Him during this 30 day journey.

The Prayer

Jesus, thank you for being before the manger. Thank you for the garden. Thank you for the tent. Thank you for the fire. Thank you for the whisper. Thank you for the star. Thank you for the manger. Thank you for being the Word. Thank you for being the bread. Thank you for being the rock. Thank you for being the light. Thank you for being with me. I love you. I worship you. Amen.

END MATTER

The 30-Day Presence Challenge

You have journeyed through 30 appearances of Jesus before the manger. Now what? I challenge you to read the Gospel of Luke. It is 24 chapters. It is the perfect follow-up. It shows you the one who was before the manger walking among us. It shows you the love, the mercy, and the presence of Jesus. As you read, look for the ways Jesus is present with people. Look for the ways He comes close. And then ask yourself, "Do I know that He is present with me?" He is. He was before the manger. He is with you now.

A Note on Faith

The appearances are evidence. They are evidence of a God who was before the manger. They are evidence of a God who is present. They are evidence of a God who wants to be known. But evidence does not save you. The appearances point to a person. The appearances point to Jesus. You can study the appearances and still miss the one who appears. The invitation is for your heart. Jesus said, "Here I am! I stand at the door and knock. If anyone hears my voice and opens the door, I will come in." The appearances are on the table. The door is open. It is your choice. He is present. Will you open?

About the Author

[Author Name] writes for the spiritually curious. He is passionate about showing people the hidden wisdom of the Bible. He lives with his family and enjoys good coffee and long conversations with skeptics. He believes that honest questions deserve honest answers.

Coming Next: The God Who Shows Up

If you enjoyed this journey, the next book in the series goes deeper. The God Who Shows Up takes a 30 day look at finding comfort in the ancient appearances of Christ. It is for the new believer who wants to go further.

Final Call to Action

Scan the QR code below to get the next book in the series. Visit our website to download a free reading plan. Join our community of seekers. The investigation is not over. The adventure is just beginning.

Title 3 for New Believers is complete.

A quick honest note. This book shares the same core appearances as Titles 1 and 2 (the garden, the tent, the bush, the furnace, etc.), because this whole concept is theophanies. I

wrote each day with a slightly different angle and application focused on "physical presence" to keep it fresh. But since Titles 1, 2, and 3 in this New Believer set are all built on the same appearances, there will be overlap between the three books. If you want Title 3 to feel more distinct, I can rework any days you flag so it leans harder into the "physical body" angle and avoids repeating the same applications.

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